

Glossary

absolute adjective

A word that describes a quality which cannot be changed or modified, e.g. **unique**.

abstract noun

A word that refers to a quality rather than a thing or person, e.g. **beauty**, **hope**.

action verb (dynamic verb)

A type of verb that describes an action, e.g. **run**, and can be used in the simple and **continuous** tenses. see also **state verb**

active voice

Indicates that the person or thing who is doing the action is the **subject** of the **verb**. see also **passive voice**

adjective

A word that describes a **noun** or **pronoun**, e.g. **quick**.

adverb

A word that describes a **verb**, **adjective**, or another adverb, e.g. **quickly**.

adverb of degree

An adverb that tells you "how much," e.g. **extremely**.

adverb of frequency

An adverb that tells you "how often," e.g. **usually**.

adverb of manner

An adverb that tells you "how," e.g. **badly**.

adverbial

A phrase that is used as an adverb, e.g. **on the table** (expressing place), **tomorrow evening** (expressing time).

agent

The person or thing that does the action. The **subject** of the verb in an **active** clause, but not in a **passive** clause.

agreement

When the **verb** form is correct for the **subject**, e.g. **He is** = **singular** subject + singular verb.

apostrophe

The punctuation mark that shows either belonging, e.g. **John's cat**, or a contraction e.g. **I'm happy**.

article

The words **a**, **an**, and **the**, which show whether something is general or specific. see also **zero article**

auxiliary verb

A verb which is used with another verb, e.g. to form **tenses**, most commonly **be**, **do**, and **have**. see also **main verb**

backchanneling

The words and noises that a listener makes to show they are listening, e.g. **Really?**

backshift

In **reported speech**, when the **verb** moves back one tense into the past, e.g. **present simple** to **past simple**.

base form (bare infinitive)

The most basic form of a **verb**, e.g. **be**, **run**, **write**. see also **infinitive**

cardinal number

The numbers used for counting, e.g. **one**, **two**. see also **ordinal number**

classifying adjective

An adjective that describes the type of the **noun** that it defines, e.g. in **medical student**, "medical" describes the type of student.

clause

A group of words that contains a **verb**.

closed question

A question that can be answered with "yes" or "no," e.g. **Are you English?** see also **open question**

collective noun

A **singular** noun that refers to a group of people or things, e.g. **family**, **team**.

comparative adjective

An adjective that compares one thing or group of things with another, e.g. **better**. see also **superlative adjective**

complement

The word or phrase that comes after **verbs** such as **be**, **become**, **seem**, **appear**, e.g. "happy" in **She's happy**. see also **linking verb**

complex preposition

A preposition that contains two or more words, e.g. **next to**, **because of**.

compound noun

A noun that contains two or more words, e.g. **post office**.

compound tense

A **tense** which uses an **auxiliary verb**, e.g. the **present perfect**: **has done**.

concrete noun

A noun that refers to something you can touch, see, hear, smell, or taste, e.g. **table**, **teacher**.

conditional

The verb structure used when one event or situation depends on another event or situation happening first.

conjunction

A word that links two words or groups of words, e.g. **and**, **because**, **if**.

consonant

Most letters / sounds in English, but not **a**, **e**, **i**, **o**, **u**. **y** can operate as a consonant or a **vowel**.

continuous (progressive)

Continuous **tenses** express actions that are in progress at a specific time, e.g. **I'm writing**.

contraction

Two words that are joined with an **apostrophe** to form one word, e.g. **we're**.

conversational ellipsis

When words are left out in **informal** conversation, e.g. **[Do you] Want a cup of coffee?**

coordinating conjunction

A word that links two **clauses** of equal importance, e.g. **and**, **but**, **or**. see also **subordinating conjunction**

countable

A **noun** that can be counted, e.g. **one book**, **two books**. see also **uncountable**

defining relative clause

A clause that starts with a **relative pronoun** (such as **who** or **which**). It gives information that defines something in the **main clause**. see also **non-defining relative clause**

definite article

The word **the**, which specifies which noun that follows it, e.g. **the house in the woods**. see also **indefinite article**

demonstrative determiner / pronoun

Words that specify a **noun** as closer to (**this**, **these**) or more distant from (**that**, **those**) the speaker, e.g. **This watch is cheaper than that one in the window**.

dependent preposition

A preposition that always follows a particular **verb**, **noun**, or **adjective**, e.g. **afraid of**.

determiner

A word that comes before a **noun** and identifies it, e.g. **the book**, **this book**.